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Fitness: A Dynamic Trend in Kathmandu

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--By Rashika Pokharel

Fitness centres and health clubs in Nepal are captivating the health-conscious people by storm. Gone are the days when morning workout was done exclusively in schools. These days there is no longer a lack of exercise gears or premium fitness centres and gyms. A growing health conscious lifestyle can be observed in Kathmandu. People have become more eager to shape their overall health. This can also be seen as the result of rapid globalization and health consciousness.

The conventional food habit of Nepali people especially in Kathmandu has significantly changed within these years. Earlier, gym was the only place known as a fitness centre where few types of fitness equipments would be available. However, now many new fitness centres, well equipped with enough modern fitness equipments for cardiovascular exercises, toning, etc, have been established. These new fitness services have offered people of different age groups the opportunity to get in shape.

Booming fitness centres that consists of not only the traditional methods of exercises but also modern forms of fitness activities like Zumba, aerobics, cardiovascular exercises, Kickboxing, etc., are attracting more people every day. Especially, the housewives and working professionals have started devoting their time to fitness activities. Increasing health awareness among Nepalis is evident through the stress that they now put on being healthy not only physically but mentally as well as socially.

Start of fitness centre in Kathmandu Valley

Nepal Byayaam Mandir in Jyatha is considered to be the first fitness centre in Kathmandu, was formed in 2010 B.S. "Along with the passage of time, the overall concept of fitness in Kathmandu has been commercialized," says Ocean Fitness Health Centre's Fitness Advisor, Deepak Ale.

Not long ago, there was a pattern of such physically active lives that individuals didn't require working out. They bicycled or walked to work and food was not overloaded with excessive carbohydrates and alcohol intake was minimal. There are many parts of Nepal that are similar to that, but Kathmandu has moved into an inactive, stressful and less healthy lifestyle more common to the fast-paced metropolis in East Asia. Now the health clubs have grown all over the Valley, influencing not just the rich, famous and the over-weight, but also attracting many middle-class Nepali professionals.

The Fitness Business

The fitness business is mounting in present context as there are more than 70 Fitness Centres within the Kathmandu Valley. This fact states that people are being more inclined towards being involved in fitness activities. Looking from the business perspective, fitness centres are evolving to being more brand concerned. The fitness form like Zumba has also successfully been able to mark their presence through the brand image. As such, Zumba fitness has become a globally renowned brand.

Various fitness centres in the valley are granting a competitive environment for each other. Every fitness centre tries to provide as much facilities as possible with a stated price. "We are offering fitness oriented activities but are also providing various dance forms which is also an amalgamation of fitness and entertainment like b-boying and salsa" says Dilip Sawad, Chairman of United fitness and Dance Studio. He further states, "We offer special package for Zumba fitness which costs Rs 3000 per month for everyday classes. Similarly, we provide classes on Rs 2000 per month for alternate day in a week.

The future prospect of Fitness

The fitness business has a very good future. There is an evolution in health awareness and people are being more health conscious. This is the reason for the overall blooming up of Fitness Centres within the Kathmandu Valley. The overall flourishing fitness trend has acted as a source of income generation. People have stopped taking their health status for granted as they have started working out, contributing their little time as possible. Fitness world is dynamic and evolutionary as new fitness trends are adding and old ones are being improvised. People are taking the fitness world to a whole new stage to which at some point may be a part of an individual's life. Hence, Fitness centres are still growing, the people are actively participating and this is a continuous process. In order to escape from their day to day stress in life they find these fitness centres as their only last hope to alleviate their stress.